



Creating a Buzz

While marketing encourages the sale of your products and services, public relations (PR) aims to promote your business and brand. It is a valuable tool to help gain interest, customer loyalty, and sales.



Understanding publicity

As a new business owner, it is important to learn how to use PR to generate and maintain a positive image of your company and brand. It is key to establishing your brand's personality (see pp.60–61), and can strongly influence how willing people are to deal with you, including customers, suppliers, and even investors.

PR is an ongoing process that starts by creating a public image of your brand, what it is, and what it stands for. It then uses publicity to carefully manage how the business or brand is perceived externally.

Generating media coverage is a vital PR tool in order to reach your audience. For example, a journalist or online influencer writing about your business will give you valuable, free publicity. When launching your business, publicize the story behind your brand, and why you launched it (see pp.62–63). Plan events, such as open days, enter for relevant trade or community awards, and share interesting news stories about your business. Take advantage of free internet monitoring services, such as Google Alerts, to keep track of any media mentions, as well as to follow competitors.



USE THE INTERNET

The internet provides a wealth of free opportunities to publicize your business. If possible, build your own website, or make use of social media and local forums.

- › **Advertise events** and special promotions to attract people to your business.
- › **Share news stories** about your business, such as interesting events, new products and services, or notable achievements.
- › **Create online profiles** of yourself and staff to give your business a human face. Update them regularly and use them to promote the business.

BECOME PART OF THE COMMUNITY

People like to support their communities, including local businesses, which you can benefit from - as part of the community.

- › **Organise open days**, where the public can meet you and your staff, and see what your business offers.
- › **Join local** business groups and contribute to the local area. Share your involvement.
- › **Sponsor local activities** and initiatives, and attend shows and events. Help raise funds for local good causes and charities.